

“The Black Box”

(7th October, 2022)

Author's Note: *This piece was written during my final years of high school. I've chosen to preserve it as it was originally written because it reflects the person I was at that stage of my life and the experiences that shaped me.*

A withering 8-inch black shoebox sits on the bottommost shelf of a white cupboard in a purple-walled room. Its lid screams “DO NOT TOUCH” and “BELONGS TO HANISHA” in a shaky red sparkle ink. Inside its weary cardboard skin rests my childhood memories. Since it is impossible to show a video recording of every second of my life, relive my defining moments through the items in this box.

Cross-legged, I sit on the floor with the box in my lap. As I reach my hands inside the box, the first thing I grab is a pink teacup, part of a complete kitchen set for kids. It takes me back to when I was five and was obsessed with make-believe cooking with my sisters. That was the first time I worked in a team. One sister would mix the mud with water, and the other would hunt the garden for flowers to decorate the chocolate cake while I shaped the cake with the muddy slurry. Together we would make the perfect dish, a taste of success!

Next, I pull out a yellow badge with a silver border and a roaring lion in the center with the word “Captain.” It was shinier when it sat on the left side of my school shirt for three years—marking me out from the crowd as a student council member. The lengthy brainstorming sessions to choose songs or costumes for the music and dance competition, the late-night track editing, and the numerous discussions I had with management to get my team more rehearsal time were all factors that contributed to winning the competitions. In victory and loss, my team and I stood together.

The delegate handbook of SMISMUN, my school’s Model United Nations, barely fits in the box. I worked in the secretariat for two years as *Head of the Organizing Committee and Event Coordinator*. I endured sleepless nights and meal-less days to expand my school’s network by working with food trucks and DJs, organizing social nights, and opening and closing ceremonies. My communication skills developed in requesting over 500 delegates to participate in our MUN. I helped make content for our MUN’s Instagram page. The number of delegate handbooks packed was countless, but staying back in school to complete these tasks with my peers and seniors made it all pass in a breeze.

The box then pushes out the polaroid of *Right To A Good Bite’s* (RTAGB) first club meeting on 21st May 2020, bringing happy tears to my eyes. I started *RTAGB* at school to raise awareness about the relation of food and diet to mental and physical health. Over time, with increasing passionate club members, it became a safe space for conversations in school. Our internal discussions led to researched seminars, invited talks by health professionals, and creative plays on the issues for the entire school to attend. On our Instagram page, we posted parodies, posts,

and reels on our monthly topics, such as eating disorders, organic farming, food adulteration, and “Covid: Food Myth-Busting.”

The last item is a black journal with the faded minions’ stickers. I opened the page containing a bucket list I made when I was eight. Amongst them, the already checked boxes read: getting a phone, a picnic at a waterpark, becoming a student council member, helping the community, and more. The remaining unchecked box read: being the first person in my family to study abroad, becoming a successful entrepreneur, developing innovative products, buying a house, and many other dreams which I am working to accomplish in my life. As I closed my eyes, I recalled my achievements and the hurdles I crossed to procure them. I became an improved person at every stage, making meaningful contributions to the team. Sometimes my leadership brought us closer to victory; other times, my backhanded support in the group made me appreciate the value of teamwork.